

underwent a change not only in subject and spirit but in technique.”

BRUSH WITH BEAUTY

An avant-garde artist who created a new genre of art, she came to symbolise a progressive identity. In her all-too brief but shining life, she pushed the limits of art and liberty.

■ By Vivan Sundaram

Amrita is known to the world in different ways—some know her through her paintings and some through her persona. But whether it's her young, brash and outspoken personality or the stark colours she used, she stood out most for her questioning nature. It was her relentless project to find out and quench her curiosity. And she did this through her palette.

Amrita's ancestry was indeed a big cause of the flux one sees in her pictures. But one must also consider the time. She lived in an era when India itself was in transition. With so much going around her, the young Amrita was sucked into a vortex of change. With a mother who was Hungarian and a father who was a strident Indian, Amrita was intensely conscious of where she was from and who she was. She was also conscious of her physical beauty in more ways than one, which can be seen in the enormous number of visuals available of her, the majority taken by her father Umrao Singh himself. In my gradual excavations of her life, I have come across many glamorous pictures of Amrita, who was cosmopolitan and extremely fashionable. This perhaps has by now created an “image” of her, which only sometimes complements her real skill as an artist.

Amrita will be remembered as a free, liberated woman who came to India and took it by storm. A painting that comes to me in particular,

whenever I recall her, is *Two Girls*. It was painted when she was in Hungary, around two years before she died. It is special in the feminism that very obviously comes across. It is one where Amrita had confronted her own interpretation of the feminine and is significant in the context of her art.

Being from the same family has influenced me on different levels. My mother, Indira Sundaram, never talked about her sister Amrita but her paintings were all over our home. They were part of the domain lodged in the home spatiality. It was only when I started learning art that I became aware of her fully. Since then, I have been inscribing her into my own work by studying her art and her personal history for decades now. The first apparent exploration was the oil painting that I did 22 years ago of the Sher-Gill family. The attempts continued and so did my own journey in art. Through this I came to realise many things about Amrita and slowly, the artist turned into a person for me, as someone who had her own demons to take on, but despite that lived her life as a tour de force.

Amrita came to symbolise a progressive identity—that of a nationalist Indian. Even though Hungarian literature was central to her being, on her return, she was very curious about her paternal lineage and that is when perhaps her artistic experimentation began. It is indeed interesting to know that her art wasn't breaking barriers when she was abroad. Her conscious

change came here. The tension between her two identities created a frisson that can today be called modern Indian art. Her subjects changed. She was always interested in the female body but now she went on to painting working women, who, to her, held immense interest in their bright colours and tough survival. These were either members of her paternal family or an observation of the working women at her estate in Gorakhpur. At that time, she faced criticism for painting in oil, which wasn't a practice in India. But she continued, undeterred.

Amrita, in the end, fulfills for me an example of the modern Indian woman even though it's a cliché now. This is asserted in her art practice, and in her extreme consciousness of being a woman. Her 28 years of existence were a constant attempt to establish her identity vis-à-vis her art practice. One can call her one of the pioneers of modern Indian art. Her project was a conscious one—to create a synthesis of Indian pictorial traditions and a modern style. One that she succeeded in immensely. Her hunt for that pinnacle of art made her travel adventurously and she sought to meet people of the arts all the time. Her gradual discovery of herself and in the end her introspection ensured her a place in the annals of world art.

as told to Bushra Ahmed

The author is a contemporary Indian artist and Sher-Gill's nephew